

**Treated or Contaminated? How Media Systems Shaped Coverage of the Fukushima
Water Discharge in Japan, China and South Korea**

COMM2891 Asian Media and Communication

Assignment 1: Major Research Essay

Topic: Japan's Treated Fukushima Nuclear Wastewater Discharge

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On 24 August 2023, the operator of the wrecked Fukushima Daiichi nuclear plant began releasing water into the Pacific that had been processed by the Advanced Liquid Processing System (ALPS) and diluted. A month earlier, the International Atomic Energy Agency had concluded that the plan was consistent with international safety standards and would have a “negligible radiological impact” on people and the environment (International Atomic Energy Agency [IAEA], 2023). Yet the same event was reported in sharply different ways across East Asia, and even its name was disputed. Japanese officials and most domestic media called it “treated water” (*shorisui*), Chinese state media called it “nuclear-contaminated water” (*he wuran shui*), and South Korean outlets were divided between “contaminated” (*oyeomsu*) and “treated” (*cheorisu*) water.

This essay compares coverage in Japan with coverage in two neighbours, China and South Korea, from Japan’s 2021 decision to the aftermath of the 2023 release. It examines traditional media (newspapers, broadcasters and state media) and emerging media (social platforms, video sites and online influence operations). It argues that coverage in all three countries converged on a national-interest frame in which terminology was the main framing device. The disparities, however, reflect each country’s media system: the relationship between media and the state, the degree of political parallelism, and each government’s geopolitical position. Emerging media amplified these patterns rather than overturning them.

Key Concepts and Analytical Framework

Two concepts guide the analysis. First, framing means selecting some aspects of a perceived reality and making them more salient in order to promote a particular problem definition, causal interpretation, moral evaluation and remedy (Entman, 1993). Operationally, this essay treats the name given to the water, the sources quoted and the actor held

responsible as indicators of a frame. A “national-interest frame” is one in which the problem is defined by what the discharge means for the reporting nation’s safety, economy or standing, rather than by the evidence alone. Second, media systems are compared using the framework that distinguishes Liberal, Democratic Corporatist and Polarized Pluralist models along four dimensions: market development, political parallelism, journalistic professionalism and state intervention (Hallin & Mancini, 2004). Political parallelism, the extent to which media structures and content mirror political divisions, has since been operationalised as a measurable variable, so it travels better than the Western-derived models themselves (Hallin & Mancini, 2017).

None of the three cases fits these models neatly. China lies outside them and resembles the older authoritarian and Soviet communist theories of the press, in which media serve the ruling party (Siebert et al., 1956), updated for the platform era by netizens who co-produce official persuasion (Repnikova & Fang, 2018). Japan combines low overt partisanship with close reporter–official ties through *kisha* (press) clubs, producing a relatively homogeneous news environment, whereas South Korea’s is pluralistic and polarised (Arrington, 2017). Higher political parallelism is also associated with more interventionist and critical journalism (Lee et al., 2024). Press freedom rankings reflect these differences only roughly: in 2025 South Korea ranked 61st, Japan 66th and China 178th (Reporters Without Borders [RSF], 2025).

Japan: Scientific Safety and a Policed Vocabulary

Japanese mainstream coverage was organised around a “scientific safety” frame supported by international authority. The government built technical legitimacy by foregrounding the IAEA’s conclusions, and the mainstream press largely echoed this frame (C. Sun et al., 2026). In the initial phase, the *Japan Times* combined scientific evidence, details of the treatment process and counter-blaming of critics into a discourse of “image

protection” (Gong et al., 2024). The boundaries of the frame were actively policed. When Agriculture Minister Tetsuro Nomura called the water “contaminated” in August 2023, the slip was reported as echoing Beijing, and he apologised and retracted it (“Fisheries Minister Under Fire,” 2023). Criticism therefore focused on process and livelihoods, such as fishers’ consent and reputational damage (*fuhyo higai*) to Fukushima seafood, rather than on the science. This relative uniformity is what the Japanese system predicts. Press clubs give member outlets privileged access to official sources and homogenise content (Arrington, 2017), and Japanese watchdog journalism takes a restrained “doubting” form rather than the “criticizing” style found in South Korea (Lee et al., 2024). In Japan, then, parallelism runs less towards parties than towards official sources, which explains why the government’s label became the default vocabulary of news.

Emerging media revealed a less settled public mood. Japanese YouTube comments showed significantly negative sentiment towards government responses and the release, with negative comments clustering around the ruling party, the prime minister and the plant operator (Y. Sun et al., 2025). Online scepticism was therefore directed at domestic institutions rather than at the scientific case. After the release the story shifted again. When Fukushima city offices and schools received hundreds of harassing calls from Chinese numbers, Japanese media recast Japan as the target of foreign hostility (“Japan Urges China,” 2023), and ministers ate Fukushima fish for the cameras to demonstrate its safety (Associated Press, 2023).

China: Party-State Framing and Online Nationalism

Chinese coverage was uniform and led by the state. On the day of the release, the Foreign Ministry said that China “firmly opposes and strongly condemns” the “unilateral” discharge of “nuclear-contaminated water” and accused Japan of “spreading the risks to the rest of the world” (Ministry of Foreign Affairs of the People’s Republic of China [MFA],

2023). State media adopted the same vocabulary. *China Daily* built a discourse of politically driven public health concern that attributed the decision to the US–Japan alliance and disputed its scientific basis (Gong et al., 2024), while official outlets used metaphors that cast the release as a war and Japan and the plant operator as liars (Li & Chen, 2024). Against Japan’s scientific safety frame, China advanced an “environmental justice” frame stressing historical accountability and ecological risk (C. Sun et al., 2026). Xinhua also amplified an allegation by two small South Korean outlets, based on an anonymous informant, that Japan had struck a “black deal” with the IAEA over its report (Xinhua, 2023). This homogeneity fits the party-state model, in which foreign-policy positions set the limits of news framing and foreign voices are selected to confirm them.

Emerging media amplified the official frame instead of diversifying it. A Weibo graphic from a CCTV-linked account, claiming that Japan had spent 70 billion yen on public relations, drew 667 million views on the platform’s trending list, while an article criticising anti-Japanese arguments was quickly censored (Freedom House, 2023). An analysis of 56,526 Weibo posts found that early technical and environmental discussion gave way to nationalist rhetoric that combined anti-Japanese grievance with anti-Western scepticism, and that ordinary users rather than verified accounts led this shift (Qin & Lee, 2026). This illustrates authoritarian participatory persuasion, in which the state invites netizens to reproduce its messages (Repnikova & Fang, 2018). The effects spread offline: after Beijing’s condemnation and its blanket ban on Japanese seafood, consumers emptied shelves of salt and avoided seafood stalls (Hall & Zhang, 2023). The frame also crossed borders, as a state-linked network posted hundreds of Korean-language messages amplifying South Korean protests against the discharge (Microsoft Threat Analysis Center [MTAC], 2024).

South Korea: Polarised Coverage That Followed Its Government

South Korea is the most revealing comparison because its coverage changed with its government. In 2021, when the progressive Moon Jae-in administration opposed Japan's decision, the *Korea Herald* constructed a blaming discourse around Japan's irresponsibility, history and human rights (Gong et al., 2024). The conservative Yoon Suk Yeol administration, which took office in 2022 and sought rapprochement with Tokyo, said it "respects" the IAEA's findings without endorsing the release ("Yoon Faces Mounting Protests," 2023). Coverage then divided along partisan lines, reflecting a newspaper market in which the conservative *Chosun Ilbo* and the progressive *Hankyoreh* have long acted as opposing political camps (Chang, 2025). Headlines in two conservative and two progressive dailies from 2019 to 2024 initially shared the keyword "concern". After 2022, however, conservative papers replaced it with "disinformation", pairing it with "mad cow disease" and "fake news", while progressive papers portrayed the disinformation label as a ruling-party weapon (Kim, 2026). Similarly, progressive outlets emphasised environmental risk, public health and government accountability, whereas conservative outlets foregrounded diplomacy and governance. Polarisation peaked before the release, and strongly partisan outlets held their positions afterwards (Chang, 2025).

Politicians also acted out the competing frames for the cameras. Opposition leader Lee Jae-myung staged a hunger strike and called the president "complicit" in Japan's "nuclear terrorism", while ruling-party lawmakers dined at seafood restaurants to show that fish was safe ("Fukushima Release Has South Korean Politicians," 2023). Public anxiety nevertheless crossed party lines. A joint Korean–Japanese newspaper poll found that 84% of South Koreans disapproved of the release, and panic buying pushed up salt prices two months before the discharge (Kuhn, 2023). This pattern resembles the Polarized Pluralist model, in

which high political parallelism makes outlets partisan interpreters of events (Hallin & Mancini, 2004; Lee et al., 2024).

Similarities, Disparities and Their Causes

Set side by side, the three cases share important similarities. Each national media ecology turned a transboundary scientific question into a national one, with the name of the water acting as the decisive frame (Entman, 1993). Leaders in both Japan and South Korea staged seafood meals to perform safety, using symbolic reassurance in place of technical explanation. Emerging media also amplified risk beyond professional reporting. Salt panics occurred in China and South Korea, and online discourse in all three countries turned towards blame, directed either at Japan or at the commentator's own government (Kuhn, 2023; Qin & Lee, 2026; Y. Sun et al., 2025). Finally, the three media spheres were not sealed off from one another. Chinese state media recycled Korean allegations, and state-linked accounts fed Korean protests, so emerging media carried frames across borders as well as within them (MTAC, 2024; Xinhua, 2023).

Four factors explain the disparities. The first is the media system. Chinese coverage was uniform because the party-state set the frame, and Korean coverage was polarised because outlets mirror party divisions. Japanese coverage was relatively uniform for a different reason: institutionalised access to official sources (Arrington, 2017; Lee et al., 2024). The second is the government's position, which the media largely followed. The Korean shift from blaming Japan in 2021 to a partisan contest after 2022 tracked the change of government, suggesting that Korean parallelism operates towards the state as well as towards parties (Gong et al., 2024; Kim, 2026). The third is geopolitics and historical memory: China's frame drew on wartime grievance and rivalry with the United States, while Seoul's conservative government aligned with Tokyo (Qin & Lee, 2026). The fourth is

platform governance. Weibo's state-managed trending lists channelled nationalism outward, whereas Japanese and Korean users could turn their distrust on their own governments.

These findings complicate a simple contrast between Japanese "science" and Chinese "propaganda". Japan's frame was also strategic. Its technical rationality sidelined the lived experience of local fishers (C. Sun et al., 2026), and its image-protection discourse served national reputation (Gong et al., 2024). Equally, Chinese online nationalism was not purely top-down (Qin & Lee, 2026). The Western-derived models are therefore most useful as dimensions rather than fixed categories.

Conclusion

This essay has argued that coverage of the Fukushima discharge was shaped less by the scientific evidence, which was available in all three countries, than by who controlled the frame. Japan's press-club system produced a relatively uniform "treated water" narrative that emerging media challenged mainly through distrust of domestic institutions. China's party-state produced a uniform "nuclear-contaminated water" narrative that Weibo users amplified into nationalism and that state-linked networks exported. South Korea's politically parallel media divided the same facts along partisan lines, and the dominant frame shifted with the government. The shared features, national framing and online amplification of risk, show that emerging media intensified existing dynamics rather than displacing professional or state media. The differences confirm that media-system models remain useful for explaining Asian media, provided their dimensions are adapted to East Asian relations between the state and the media. For audiences, the lesson is that the word chosen to describe the water was itself a political signal, and reading coverage across borders is necessary to see how each frame was built.

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